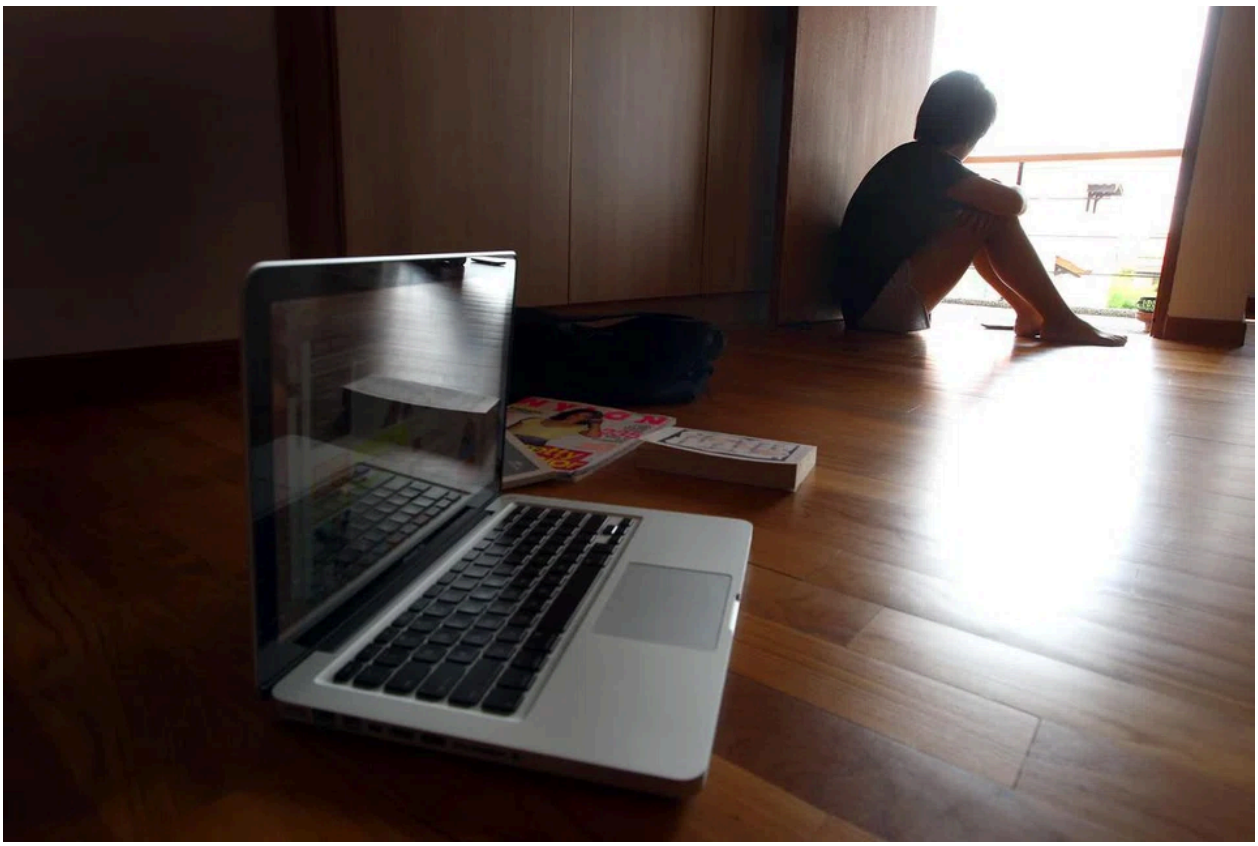
The relentless nature of cyber bullying and why Singapore schools must remain vigilant

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In July 2024, a survey found that 74 per cent of internet users face harmful content like cyber bullying or sexual content online, but only a quarter of them report it.

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SINGAPORE - Schools are encouraged to keep up to date on cyber trends and issues, such as through resources provided by the Ministry of Education (MOE), said a lead school counsellor from the ministry's guidance branch.

Students also play an active role in alerting teachers when there are new online trends and platforms that are concerning, said Ms Jane Lim.

"In my current role of supporting school counsellors, I have observed that cyber-bullying incidents often extend from offline hurtful behaviours to online platforms and occur alongside other forms of bullying," she added.

For example, some students may make “hurtful remarks” to their peers on social media or messaging apps, or create fake social media profiles impersonating others.

MOE was responding to queries from The Straits Times about the recent spate of bullying cases that have made headlines, and how schools handle reports of bullying and put in place anti-bullying measures.

In September, two videos of bullying incidents surfaced online, showing primary and secondary school students hitting their fellow schoolmates.

“Bullying is not acceptable and has no place in our schools,” said MOE, adding that students are taught values of respect, care and empathy during character and citizenship education (CCE) classes.

“They are taught to walk away from bullies and seek help from trusted adults.

“These lessons extend to the cyberspace where the CCE curriculum teaches students to be respectful and responsible learners online.”

Dr Annabelle Chow, a clinical psychologist at Annabelle Psychology and Annabelle Kids, said her clinic has seen an increase in reported incidents of cyber bullying, especially since the Covid-19 pandemic.

“As students spend more time online, social media platforms are rife hot spots for online harassment.”

In July 2024, a survey by the Ministry of Digital Development and Information found that 74 per cent of internet users face harmful content like cyber bullying or sexual content online, but only a quarter of them report it.

And in February 2024, it was reported that one in five gamers between 13 and 18 years old felt bullied by other players in games, according to the first youth online gaming survey by the then Ministry of Communications and Information.

Cyber bullying and psychological manipulation like spreading rumours, online harassment and the use of deepfakes are more common than people think, said Dr Chow, because they can be done with anonymity and ease.

“Cyber bullies hide behind screens, using fake accounts or pseudonyms, and avoid facing detection or consequences,” she said.

“This sense of anonymity emboldens individuals to engage in harmful behaviour without the same fear of being caught as in traditional bullying.”

Associate Professor of Psychology (Education) Andree Hartanto from the School of Social Sciences at Singapore Management University said cyber bullying is “often more persistent, more psychological and emotional in nature, and can spread to a wider audience quickly”.

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While physical and verbal bullying typically occurs face to face and is confined to specific contexts such as school, cyber bullying is “relentless”, he added.

“Victims can experience harassment around the clock, even within the perceived safety of their homes, leading to increased levels of stress, anxiety and depression,” he said, adding that anonymity on digital platforms contributes to a “sense of powerlessness” among victims.

“This lack of control is associated with a higher risk of emotional trauma compared with traditional bullying,” said Prof Hartanto.

MOE said it provides schools with resources on the latest cyber trends and issues, including real-life case studies.

Peer support leaders, who are also students, help to keep online and offline spaces safe, and alert teachers of cases, it added.

But cyber bullying is more discreet and may be harder to identify, said Dr Chow.

“Victims may feel ashamed to speak up or fear that others may believe manipulated content such as altered images or videos shared on social media over their own testimony,” she said, adding that anonymity lets the bullies target victims without fear of repercussions.

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